

Furnace Emergency Homeowner Guide — Action Checklist

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GATHER FURNACE INFORMATION FIRST

- ❑ **Gather Furnace Information First:** Locate the rating plate inside your furnace cabinet and write down the brand name, model number, serial number, fuel type, and BTU rating so you have documentation to reference when discussing repairs with contractors.
- ❑ **Gather Furnace Information First:** Search for your furnace's error codes using the manufacturer website and your specific brand name to decode what the blinking LED light pattern means before a technician arrives at your home.
- ❑ **Gather Furnace Information First:** Use the model number you found to look up repair manuals and verify that any parts quoted to you are actually compatible with your specific unit model before agreeing to any work.
- ❑ **Gather Furnace Information First:** Assess whether your situation truly qualifies as an emergency requiring immediate service or if it can wait for regular business hours to avoid emergency pricing surcharges that can be 1.5x to 2x higher.

GET MULTIPLE WRITTEN ESTIMATES

- ❑ **Get Multiple Written Estimates:** Request a detailed, itemized quote with a clear scope of work from every contractor so you can identify and refuse charges for work that was never discussed, performed, or needed.
- ❑ **Get Multiple Written Estimates:** Obtain at least two or three written estimates from different contractors before accepting any repair or replacement quote to establish a baseline for comparison and identify outliers.
- ❑ **Get Multiple Written Estimates:** Ask each contractor to explain whether the problem warrants repair or replacement based on your furnace's actual condition, since some contractors favor replacements regardless of what your unit actually needs.
- ❑ **Get Multiple Written Estimates:** Never sign anything or authorize work until you have compared all itemized estimates side by side and understand exactly what each line item covers and why it is necessary.

RECOGNIZE COMMON OVERPAYMENT TRAPS

- ☐ **Recognize Common Overpayment Traps:** Watch for contractors who add charges for work they claim to have noticed while on-site, such as old venting or unrelated components, without prior discussion or written authorization from you.
 - ☐ **Recognize Common Overpayment Traps:** Be aware that a contractor whose business model leans toward new installations may recommend replacement when a repair would extend your existing unit's life for several more years.
 - ☐ **Recognize Common Overpayment Traps:** Remember that you have no way to verify claims about blink codes or fault conditions unless you have already looked them up yourself, so always check manufacturer resources before accepting a technician's diagnosis.
 - ☐ **Recognize Common Overpayment Traps:** Understand that accepting the first quote simply because you want the problem solved and someone competent is already in your house is not a valid reason to pay an inflated or unfair price.
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